

my husband has written one or more checks he didn't tell me about. This really discourages me, and then I get sloppy about balancing our account. But I can't stand to think about the account out of balance, so I'll start keeping the checkbook again. Do you have any suggestions?

ANSWER: I would say it sounds like a typical "you keep the books, but leave me alone" attitude on the part of your husband.

There is absolutely no way anyone can maintain good accounting over the home finances without both husband and wife cooperating.

I would first suggest discussing honestly how you feel with your husband. It may be necessary to see a counselor who can interface between you. If, however, after making every possible attempt to work on this problem together, you find your husband still will not cooperate, you need to turn the books over to him.

It may mean that the finances will get in a mess and bills won't get paid. That's always a risk. But until you work together, you will continue to feel the frustration you now feel.

Before turning the books over, you need to be sure you communicate that frustration to your husband *clearly*. You also need to be sure you can handle the chaos that normally follows. You need to be a helpmate (supporter) to your husband, but not a buffer.

QUESTION 8. How do we decide on a car budget?

My fiancée and I both have fairly new cars that are special to us. When we're married, the joint costs will run about 30 percent of our budget. Any suggestions?

ANSWER: Yes. Sell one of your cars. Your car budget doesn't have to be the exact amount—15 percent—that I indicated in chapter 12. You may be able to go over a few percentage points. But remember, for every percentage over in one category, you must be the same percentage under in the other